

Farmers Rebuild After Devastating Floods



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The Mpumalanga Department of Agriculture, Rural Development, Land and Environmental Affairs MEC, Khethiwe Moeketsi, has conducted an oversight visit in Bushbuckridge Local Municipality to assess government responses to farm interventions and disaster relief following recent floods.

The visit focused on three key projects – the Dingleddale Irrigation Scheme, Benica Farms in Acornhoek and Mariti

Harvest – and was undertaken alongside the municipal executive led by Executive Mayor Lydia Moroane, Council Speaker Ruth Raganya, Chief Whip Malandule, MMC for Economic Development, Environment and Planning Patricia Gubayi, ward councillors and community representatives.

At the Dingleddale Irrigation Scheme, farmers were assured that refurbishment of the canal, severely damaged by

heavy rains and flooding, will begin soon. Crops were destroyed, while irrigation systems, smart box infrastructure and furrow irrigation channels were badly affected.

The 1 748-hectare scheme, established in 1966, supports more than 300 families who depend on the canal for their livelihoods. Farmers from the scheme supply produce to the Government Nutrition Programme as well as major retailers including Boxer, Spar, Pick n

Pay and Shoprite in Thulamahashe, Bushbuckridge and Acornhoek.

In Acornhoek, the delegation visited Benica Farms, a multi-award-winning, SAP GAP-certified operation led by co-founders Bennedict and Veronica Mhlongo.

The farm supplies fresh vegetables, fruit and processed products to local retailers. As part of the intervention, the department donated 15 000 spinach seedlings, 15 000 cabbage seedlings and five 50kg bags of fertiliser.

In Mariti, the team visited the mixed-farming project Mariti Harvest, led by 28-year-old Makhutso Mnisi. The farm, which specialises in horticulture and exports agricultural produce, received 4 000 Raja chilli seedlings, 5 000 spinach seedlings, 1 500 tomato seedlings and five 50kg bags of fertiliser. Mnisi said the visit had renewed his motivation to grow the business.

All the farms employ local workers, contribute to the local economy and support surrounding communities. They also supply produce to government nutrition programmes and regional retailers.

The oversight visit highlighted both the resilience of local farmers and the critical role of government support in rebuilding infrastructure, restoring production and strengthening sustainable agriculture in flood-affected rural communities.

CRIME

Stolen vehicle recovered on N4



COMMUNITY

Community Rallies Behind Learners in Need



SPORTS

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SPiritual REBIRTH

Kingdom Message Sparks Sudden Call

After John’s arrest, Jesus went into Galilee declaring God’s good news: the time had come and the kingdom was near. He called people to turn back to God and believe the message. Walking beside the Sea of Galilee, he saw Simon and his brother Andrew casting a net, for they were fishermen. Jesus invited them to follow him and promised a new purpose: they would become “fishers of people”. Immediately they left their nets and went with him.

A little further on, he saw James and John, sons of Zebedee, in their boat mending nets. Jesus called them as well. At once they left their father with the hired men and followed him.

The passage captures urgency and disruption. John is detained, uncertainty hangs in the air, yet Jesus moves forward with a public announcement and a practical invitation. Ordinary working people are the first to respond, not by debating, but by acting. Their quick decision suggests trust that outweighs routine, income, and expectation.

In a small fishing community, such departures would have been noticed—boats understaffed, families reshuffling, partners absorbing the workload—signalling that this kingdom message is not merely spiritual talk, but a call that changes daily life.

Crumbling Classrooms Endanger Mzinti Learners



Mzinti Primary School.

Learners at Mzinti Primary School are attending classes in buildings described as structurally unsafe, raising serious concerns about child safety and the state of school infrastructure in rural areas.

The condition of the school was highlighted during an oversight visit by the Provincial Legislature’s Portfolio Committee on Education on Friday, 13 February 2026. The school, established in 1942, has ageing blocks, including one built by community members. It has 18 classrooms, with one converted into a staff room — but several structures are now reportedly unfit to safely accommodate learners and educators.

According to a press statement issued by MPL Thoko Mashiane on 17 February 2026, teaching continues under the fear that ceilings or walls could collapse, especially during windy and rainy conditions. The School Governing Body (SGB) has attempted minor repairs using limited departmental maintenance funds, but the school’s condition remains a risk.

While the circuit manager facilitated the installation of six mobile classrooms in November 2024 to ease overcrowding, the statement argues this has not addressed the underlying crisis.

The situation worsened after January 2026 storms tore rooftops off four additional classrooms. Although the storm did not occur during school hours, the incident has intensified concerns about what could happen if severe weather strikes while learners are in class. Parts of the school are now said to be too unsafe for teaching and learning.

Beyond the infrastructure decay, the school is reported to be battling overcrowding, a lack of ICT resources, crime including theft

and burglary, insufficient parental support, and shortages of learning and teaching support materials such as desks and chairs.



The SGB has formally appealed to the Mpumalanga Department of Education to demolish unsafe structures and replace them with permanent, modern classrooms that are safe, dignified and suitable for learning.

Calls have also been made for urgent assessments, decommissioning of dangerous buildings, long-term planning to end overcrowding, and prioritisation of rural schools in infrastructure budgets.

The matter has renewed debate about whether temporary solutions are enough when learners’ lives may be at risk.

CRIME

Stolen vehicle recovered on N4



A suspected stolen vehicle was recovered and a foreign national arrested during a police operation on the N4 near Alkmaar, outside Nelspruit, on Monday afternoon.

According to a media statement issued by South African Police Service in Mpumalanga, members of the White River Flying Squad acted on information about a Toyota Hilux reported stolen earlier the same day in Kameldrift, Gauteng. During routine patrols, officers spotted a vehicle matching the description travelling towards Nelspruit and stopped it for inspection.

The vehicle was positively identified as the stolen Toyota Hilux GD-6. Police arrested a 26-year-old Mozambican national on a charge of possession of a suspected stolen motor vehicle.

Further investigation revealed that the bakkie was fitted with false registration plates. Some interior components had also been removed, allegedly in



preparation for the removal of a tracking device. The vehicle was taken to the Vehicle Identification Section for safekeeping and forensic investigation.

The suspect was expected to appear before the Nelspruit Magistrate’s Court on 17 February 2026.

Editor’s Note

This week, we celebrate the spirit of Bushbuckridge

In Buffelshoek Dikotase, the community came together to support two Grade 10 learners from the Malatjie family, who lacked school uniforms.

Generous donations of shirts, trousers, shoes, and even school meals are helping them attend school with confidence and pride.

Meanwhile, local farmers are rebuilding after devastating floods wiped out crops and jobs. Their resilience, with support from authorities, shows the determination of our people to rise above adversity.

These stories remind us that community and perseverance make all the difference. - Editor

Community Rallies Behind Learners in Need



The community has come together to support two learners from Moses High School in Buffelshoek Dikotase, who were in urgent need of school uniforms.

Earlier this month, the Malatjie family appealed for assistance after their son, a Grade 10 learner, missed the entire month of January because he did not have a school uniform. His sister, also in Grade 10, faced similar challenges. The family asked for any form of support, including gently used uniforms.



“We would like to sincerely thank the members of the public who contributed,” the organisers said. “Your generosity is making a real difference. Because of you, these learners can attend school with dignity, confidence, and hope.”

Special thanks were extended to Councillor Prince Sambo (Ward 21) and Bushbuckridge News for helping spread the appeal.

The organisers said the support demonstrates the power of community spirit and collective care.

The response from the public has been overwhelming. Generous donations included six shirts, three pairs of trousers, and four pairs of school shoes – two for each learner. Additionally, a donation of R100 was given to assist the children with food at school.

Through such acts of kindness, the community is helping to ensure that learners like the Malatjie siblings can continue their education without unnecessary obstacles, and are able to face each school day with pride and confidence.

Community Revives Mathibela High School



A spirit of unity, service and hope filled the grounds of Mathibela High School.

A spirit of unity, service and hope filled the grounds of Mathibela High School as a successful Back to School Campaign was hosted, bringing together learners, educators, community members and local organisations in a powerful community-driven initiative.

The programme began with a short but impactful motivational session aimed at encouraging both learners and educators as they prepare for the new academic year. The message focused on discipline, commitment, and the importance of education in shaping a better future for the youth.

This was followed by a well-organised cleaning campaign, which saw strong support from Bangwato Foundation and Makungu Security. The two organisations provided two grass cutters, cleaning equipment, and also ensured that food was available for volunteers, demonstrating practical commitment to community development.

A total of 112 volunteers participated in the campaign, working tirelessly to clean the

school premises. One of the major achievements of the day was the cutting of grass at the school’s soccer field, improving both the safety and appearance of the sporting facilities.

The programme ran from 7:00am until 2:30pm, reflecting a full day of dedicated service and community involvement.

Support for the initiative included Selby Matsane, the ANC Kaizer Mgiba Branch, Makungu Security, and Bangwato Foundation, with the entire programme facilitated by the Ward Councillor of Ward 5 in Alexandria.

The campaign stands as a strong example of what can be achieved when communities, organisations and leadership work together for a common purpose. It not only improved the physical environment of the school but also strengthened community bonds and created a positive atmosphere for learning.

This initiative sends a clear message: education is everyone’s responsibility, and collective action can make a meaningful difference in the lives of young people.



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NAWU WA MATIKHOMELO LAMANENE YA SWIRHO SWA
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LAMANE NE YA KHABINETE

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Komiti ya Nhlangelano ya Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Tsakela ka Swirho yi rhamba vatekaxiave na vanhu lava nga na ku tsakela ku yisa swibumabumelo leswi tsariweke hi mayelana na Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamenene ya Swirho swa Khabinete, 1998 (Nawu wa Nomboro ya 82 wa 1998): Ku Cinciwa ka Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene ya Swirho swa Khabinete.

Xihlambanyo xa Mpfapfarhuto xa 2025 hi Presidente wa Rhiphabliki ra Afrika-Dzonga: Ku Cinciwa ka Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene ya Khabinete wa Xihlambanyo xa Nomboro ya 41, lexi hangalasiweke eka Gazete ya Mfumo ya Nomboro ya 21399, lexi sikuhatiweke ti 28 Mawuwana 2000, hi ku ya hi xiyenge xa 2(1) xa Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene ya Swirho swa Khabinete, 1998 (Nawu wa Nomboro ya 82 wa 1998).

Swibumabumelo leswi tsariweke swi fanele ku amukeriwa ku nga se hundza 17:00 hi ti 25 Nyenyankulu 2026, naswona swi fanele ku imeyileriwa eka registrar@parliament.gov.za

Nawu wa Matikhomelo Lamanene ya Khabinete na ku Paluxiwa ka ku Tsakela ka Swirho wa sweswi wa kumeka eka <https://tinyurl.com/4ve6xxnt>

Xi humesiwile hi Muchaviseki L S Makhubela, Xirho xa Palamende na Muchaviseki JHB Britz, Xirho xa Palamende

Vatshamaxitulu Lava fambisaka swin'we va Komiti ya Nhlangelano ya swa Matikhomelo Lamanene na ku Tsakela ka Swirho

Palamende – Ku landzelerisa ku tiyimisela ka hina eka vanhu – Ku endla vumundzuku bya n'wina byi tirha ku antswa



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Allegations Cloud BLM Head Office Project

Serious allegations of mismanagement, financial irregularities and prolonged project stagnation have been raised over the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality (BLM) Head Office Project, following a formal submission by the Afrika Mayibuye Movement to the Public Protector of South Africa.

The project, intended to deliver a new municipal head office building, has reportedly remained at foundation phase since 2022, despite substantial public funds being allocated over multiple financial years.

According to documents submitted to the Public Protector, the project was approved in the 2021/2022 financial year under the municipality’s Service Delivery and Budget Implementation Plan (SDBIP), with an initial allocation of R70 million. Further allocations of R25 million in the 2022/2023 financial year and R23 million in the 2023/2024 financial year are reflected in Annual Performance Reports, with reported

project progress figures of 50% and 58.42% respectively.

However, the Afrika Mayibuye Movement alleges a serious discrepancy between reported progress and the physical state of the project site, which remains largely undeveloped.

The organisation also raises concerns over inconsistencies in the total project budget, with figures ranging between R70 million, R103 million and R118 million appearing in official documentation.

The movement’s submission to the Public Protector raises allegations relating to:

- Discrepancies between allocated budgets and visible project progress
- Prolonged delays and project stagnation
- Possible misappropriation of public funds
- Governance and accountability failures
- Inconsistencies in official performance reporting

Speaking on behalf of the organisation, Afrika Mayibuye Acting Regional Spokesperson, Cde Exodus Mabanne, said the matter required urgent intervention.

“The Afrika Mayibuye Movement believes that the alleged mismanagement of the BLM Head Office project is a serious matter that requires expedient and urgent attention. We therefore request the Public Protector to investigate this matter and take necessary actions to ensure accountability and transparency in the management of public funds.”

The organisation has formally requested the Public Protector to investigate the project’s financial management, procurement processes, accountability structures, and reporting mechanisms, as well as to identify those responsible for the alleged

mismanagement and recommend corrective measures to prevent similar incidents in future.

Bushbuckridge News sent multiple formal requests for comment to Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, seeking clarity on the project budget, expenditure, procurement process, project status, delays and governance accountability. At the time of publication, no official response had been received.

The matter raises serious public interest concerns around transparency, accountability and the management of public funds, as the project remains incomplete despite reported allocations running into tens of millions of rands.

The Public Protector’s investigation, if accepted, is expected to provide clarity on the financial, administrative and governance processes surrounding the project.

Economic Freedom Fighters (EFF) MP Sihle Lonzi used Wednesday’s State of the Nation Address (SONA) debate to slam government’s approach to youth unemployment, accusing leaders of blaming young people for a jobs crisis that is structural and deepening.

In a passionate address in Parliament, Lonzi rejected what he called an attitude that suggests the youth are “lazy” or not trying hard enough to find work. He argued that the central problem is not a lack of effort by jobseekers, but a lack of jobs and a lack of urgency from the state.

Lonzi told MPs the EFF would mobilise unemployed young people to physically deliver CVs to key state institutions — including the Union Buildings, Parliament and other government offices — as a visible reminder of the scale of joblessness. The party has framed the action as a protest against what it views as political “lip service” on employment, and a call for immediate, practical interventions.

The MP also took aim at the Youth Employment Service (YES) programme, which government frequently highlights as part of its response to youth unemployment. Lonzi labelled it a “scam”, claiming the programme places young people in short-term roles without meaningful job security and, in some cases, without reliable payment. He pointed specifically to young people placed as education assistants and said some had allegedly not been paid since last year.

Beyond criticising existing initiatives, Lonzi called for an economic shift that tackles unemployment at its roots. He argued that South Africa needs faster economic growth and a renewed focus on industrialisation, including bringing factories back to create

EFF Targets Youth Jobless Crisis



sustainable employment at scale.

His comments come at a time when youth unemployment remains one of the country’s most pressing challenges, with growing frustration among jobseekers who say they are applying repeatedly without success. Lonzi’s speech, and the EFF’s planned CV handovers, signal that the party intends to keep the issue in the public eye — and to pressure government to treat it as a national emergency.

Parliament Warns Colleges Over Foreign Hires

Parliament has issued a stern warning to universities and Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) colleges, cautioning institutions against using “internationalisation” as a loophole to sidestep South Africa’s immigration and labour laws when employing foreign nationals.

The warning was delivered during a joint meeting of the Portfolio Committee on Higher Education and Training and the Portfolio Committee on Home Affairs, where MPs raised concerns about compliance failures, weak oversight and unreliable data on foreign academic appointments across the post-school education sector. Briefings by the Department of Higher Education and Training (DHET) and the Department of Home Affairs reportedly exposed serious gaps in data management and coordination, leaving Parliament unable to properly assess whether institutions are following legal requirements when hiring foreign staff.

Higher Education and Training Minister Buti Manamela told the committees that the absence of credible data undermines effective oversight and makes it difficult to determine whether foreign nationals are being appointed to genuinely scarce and critical skills posts, or whether regulations are being bypassed.

Committee members stressed that foreign appointments must align strictly with the country’s Critical Skills framework and should not displace suitably qualified South Africans. They warned that institutions must

be able to demonstrate clear skills shortages before turning to international recruitment, particularly in roles that are not classified as scarce.

Chairperson of the Portfolio Committee on Higher Education and Training, Tebogo Letsie, said compliance is non-negotiable. “When South African students go to other countries, they are expected to follow the laws of those countries. We expect the same from those who come here,” he said, adding that internationalisation must not be used as an excuse to ignore immigration laws.



While emphasising that Parliament is not opposed to foreign academics and recognises their contributions in scarce disciplines, MPs expressed alarm over oversight findings that foreign nationals were occupying senior management and administrative posts, including principals and chief financial officers — positions not necessarily linked to critical skills.

The Home Affairs committee further warned that employing undocumented foreign nationals is a criminal offence under Section 38 of the Immigration Act, which prohibits employers from hiring foreign nationals without valid work authorisation.

The committees said they will intensify oversight, including engagement with the Department of Employment and Labour in the coming weeks, and increased scrutiny once proposed immigration-related legislation is tabled in Parliament.



Your Pad May Be Disrupting Your Flow

A new University of the Free State (UFS) study is raising fresh questions about what South Africans may be exposed to during their monthly cycle. Researchers found that every sanitary pad and pantyliner tested contained at least two hormone-disrupting chemicals, including products marketed as “free from harmful chemicals”.

Published in Science of the Total Environment, the study analysed 16 brands of sanitary pads and eight types of pantyliners sold in South African retail stores. The team screened for three groups of endocrine-disrupting chemicals (EDCs): phthalates, bisphenols (including BPA), and parabens.

The results showed widespread contamination across all products tested. Bisphenols were detected in 100% of pads and 75% of pantyliners, while parabens were found in over 81% of pads and 75% of liners. Phthalates appeared in all pantyliners tested and in 50% of sanitary pads.

Researchers said these chemicals may not always be added on purpose, but could migrate into products through plastics, adhesives, inks, and manufacturing processes.

What makes this issue especially personal is where these products are used. Menstrual pads and liners come into contact with mucosal tissue, which can absorb chemicals more directly than normal skin. While the amount in a single product might seem small, the study warns that repeated exposure over many years could add up. Long-term exposure to EDCs has been linked in research to hormonal disruption, fertility challenges, endometriosis, and certain cancers.

The study also highlights gaps in regulation and transparency. In South Africa, standards focus largely on performance and hygiene, but researchers say there are limited chemical standards for the substances detected, and manufacturers are generally not required to disclose full ingredient lists.

For consumers, the advice is practical rather than panic-driven: look for products with independent certification such as OEKO-TEX Standard 100, and consider reusable alternatives where suitable. The UFS team says it is also working on innovations, including reusable pads with antimicrobial properties.

Ultimately, the research is a call for clearer labelling, stronger safety standards, and more honest “clean” marketing—so that shoppers can make informed choices about products used month after month, year after year.

Teacher Arrested in Elukwatini Shooting



A 56-year-old teacher has been arrested following a fatal shooting in Elukwatini that left a woman dead and her daughter injured.

According to the South African Police Service (SAPS), police responded to a report of a shooting at approximately 02:10 on Saturday, 14 February 2026. On arrival, officers found a 22-year-old woman in the street with a gunshot wound to her foot.

She told police that she had been shot by her mother’s male friend and that her mother had also been shot inside the house.

Inside the residence, officers discovered the 45-year-old woman lying on the floor with a gunshot wound to the head. Emergency Medical Services certified her dead at the scene. The injured daughter was transported to hospital for medical treatment.

The suspect was found inside the house and was immediately arrested. A firearm believed to have been used in the commission of the crime was confiscated. He was initially charged with murder and attempted murder.

Court proceedings

The accused, Elijah Mdumo Mnisi (56), appeared on 16 February 2026 at the Chief Albert Luthuli Magistrate’s Court.

He now faces four charges:

- *Murder*
- *Attempted murder*
- *Sexual assault*

Handling a firearm while under the influence of alcohol

The case has been postponed to 25 February 2026 for a formal bail application, and the accused has been remanded in custody.

Foreign National Arrested for R250k Drug Bust



A 57-year-old foreign national, Patrick Izuchukwu Udeh (Nigerian), was arrested in Matafeni near Nelspruit on 18 February 2026 for dealing in drugs with an estimated street value of R250 000.

The arrest followed an intelligence-driven operation involving the SAPS Provincial Organised Crime Investigation unit, Whiteriver K9, and the Pienaar Tactical Response Team (TRT). During the raid, cocaine was recovered and seized for forensic investigation.

Udeh told police the drugs belonged to a friend who had left them for safekeeping in late January and had since fled to Johannesburg. Udeh appeared in the Nelspruit Magistrate’s Court and will return on 3 March 2026.

Inclusive Employment Drive Welcomes 21 PLWD Employees



A major step towards inclusive employment was marked as 21 new employees from the Persons Living with Disabilities (PLWD) community were officially welcomed through a transformative workplace inclusion initiative.

The onboarding programme was hosted by the Human Resource Management (HRM) unit of the Mpumalanga Department of Health, demonstrating the department’s commitment to building a more representative and equitable workforce.

The event was attended by representatives from the Office of the Premier, the local clinic and the transformation team, who participated in a meet-and-greet session with the new recruits. The programme was led by HRM Director Ms Mdluli, together with the HRM team, who addressed the employees and emphasised the importance of diversity, dignity and inclusion within the workplace.

This initiative forms part of broader efforts to increase the representation of persons with disabilities in the workforce,

aligning with the objectives of the Employment Equity Amendment Act, which proposes a target of at least 3% employment for persons with disabilities across all sectors.

The 21 employees will undergo a comprehensive induction programme that includes structured training, orientation and continuous support to ensure their seamless integration into the working environment. The department highlighted that inclusion is not only about access to jobs, but also about creating supportive spaces where employees can grow, contribute meaningfully and thrive.

Studies continue to show that inclusive workplaces benefit from diverse perspectives, increased innovation and improved employee morale — outcomes that strengthen institutional performance and service delivery.

This initiative stands as a powerful example of practical inclusion in action, reinforcing the principle that development must leave no one behind.

Mpumalanga Promises Jobs and Services



Speaking in the National Assembly during the 2026 State of the Nation Address (SONA) debate, Mandla Ndlovu outlined major plans that could directly impact communities across the province, including Bushbuckridge.

He told Parliament that Mpumalanga had reprioritised R288 million to repair infrastructure damaged by recent floods, with a further R100 million allocated through national departments. The floods claimed 20 lives in the province and displaced many families.

Health services are set to expand, with new clinics planned, more doctors placed at community health centres, and major hospitals such as Mapulaneng and the Middelburg Regional Hospital nearing completion.

Mpumalanga is also preparing for the implementation of National Health Insurance (NHI), supported by accredited health facilities and a digital

patient record system.

Education remains a priority, with 70,000 tablets set to be distributed to Grade 10 learners in 2026, following last year’s rollout to matric learners.

New schools are under construction, pit latrine toilets are being eradicated, and more than 1,300 community ECD centres have been registered and funded. Boarding schools and specialised schools for learners with disabilities are also planned.

Economic development initiatives include renewable energy projects, agricultural expansion, and large-scale hybrid rice production expected to create hundreds of thousands of jobs. Tourism developments, including projects in the Mariepskop area, were also highlighted.

Addressing Parliament in Cape Town, Ndlovu praised the leadership of Cyril Ramaphosa, particularly his response to floods in Mpumalanga and Limpopo, and said cooperative governance was key to improving service delivery and economic growth.

For communities such as Bushbuckridge, the focus on clinics, schools, disaster recovery, agriculture and job creation signals practical changes that could directly improve daily life and long-term opportunities across rural Mpumalanga.

Mpumalanga Kicks Off Mass FMD Vaccinations



Mpumalanga’s MEC for Agriculture, Rural Development, Land and Environmental Affairs, Khethiwe Moeketsi, has urged cattle farmers to tighten biosecurity and work with veterinary authorities as the province begins a mass vaccination drive against Foot and Mouth Disease (FMD).

Moeketsi officially launched the inoculation campaign in Balfour, within the Dipaleseng Local Municipality, on 13 February, warning that uncontrolled livestock movements remain one of the main drivers of the highly contagious disease. She called on farmers to refuse “suspicious” cattle brought into their areas and to verify permits and origins before allowing animals to mix with local herds.

The provincial launch followed President Cyril Ramaphosa’s announcement during the State of the Nation Address on 12 February that FMD has been classified as a national disaster.

The declaration is intended to strengthen coordination and unlock resources as outbreaks disrupt farming operations and restrict the trade of animals and animal products.

The campaign was launched at the Siyafuya Communal Kraal in Siyathemba Location, a communal livestock farming area that will serve as the first rollout point before the programme expands to other districts.

The department said the availability of additional vaccine doses has enabled Mpumalanga to begin vaccinating at scale, with Balfour marking the official start of a broader provincial rollout.

Dipaleseng has been identified as the epicentre of Mpumalanga’s outbreak, with about 35 confirmed incidents, while the wider Gert Sibande District has recorded approximately 149 confirmed outbreaks across its local municipalities.

Officials said the district remains the province’s most affected area, making rapid vaccination and strict movement controls essential.

About 80 farmers from Balfour and surrounding areas, including Grootvlei, attended the launch, where Moeketsi appealed for immediate reporting of suspected cases and for cooperation with state veterinarians enforcing animal restrictions.

Farmers were urged to stay in regular contact with veterinary services regarding quarantine measures, movement permits and other disease-management strategies.

The department reminded livestock owners to watch for typical FMD signs such as fever, excessive salivation, blisters in the mouth and on the feet, lameness and sudden drops in milk production.

Any suspected symptoms should be reported without delay to the nearest state veterinary facility.

Moeketsi said the success of the vaccination drive will depend on collective action, adding that the government cannot contain the outbreak without farmers adhering to restrictions and assisting veterinary teams with access to herds, accurate records and timely reporting.

Authorities have also warned that failure to comply with movement controls may prolong the outbreak, deepen economic losses and increase the risk of further spread to unaffected areas.

The vaccination programme will continue in phases as doses are distributed and additional sites are activated across Mpumalanga. The department said it will publish schedules as teams move from kraal to kraal.



Village Boys Secure 3 Points Against Upington City




RESULTS

	1-0	
	2-0	
	2-1	
	2-2	
	2-1	

Bushbuckridge, Mpumalanga – Kruger FC delivered the perfect Valentine's gift to their fans, claiming a hard-fought 2-1 victory over Upington City on Saturday.

The action kicked off with Celimpilo Ngema putting Kruger ahead in the 34th minute, sending the home crowd into celebrations. Both teams made tactical changes in the second half, with Kruger bringing on Khethukuthula Ndlovu for Thokozani Sibanyoni and Aphiwe Maphothe replacing Kgopotso Zitha in the 63rd minute.

Upington City fought back and equalised in the 79th minute, setting up a nail-biting finish. But it was substitute Khethukuthula Ndlovu who became the hero, scoring the decisive goal in the 85th minute to secure all three points for the village boys.

Kruger FC's fans left the stands buzzing, knowing their team had delivered not just a win, but a memorable performance on a day of love.

Final Score: Kruger 2 – Upington City 1



#	TEAM	MP	G	PTS
1.	Milford FC	18	23:14	36
2.	Kruger United	18	27:22	33
3.	Cape Town City	18	27:13	32
4.	Casric Stars	18	24:15	31
5.	Hungry Lions	18	22:16	29
6.	Venda	18	13:13	25
7.	Lerumo Lions	18	25:27	25
8.	Leicesterford City	18	14:24	24
9.	Upington City	17	22:19	22
10.	Gomora	18	17:16	22
11.	Pretoria U.	18	21:22	21
12.	Highbury	18	12:18	20
13.	The Bees	18	19:23	19
14.	Baroka	18	17:23	17
15.	Midlands Wanderers	18	12:22	17
16.	Black Leopards	17	17:25	12



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